TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Order Collection and Product Package

How orders reach a factory, the forms an order can take, the time-and-action calendar that turns a delivery date into dated duties, and the technical package that defines the product — analysed for a T-shirt, a woven shirt and pants, through to developing a new order.

TE-4104 · APPAREL MERCHANDISING AND INTERNATIONAL TRADE · TOPIC 2 · LEVEL 4 TERM 1

1. Ways and types of order

Ways an order is collected

- **Direct from the buyer.** The factory's merchandising team deals with the brand / retailer itself — full information, full responsibility, no intermediary margin.
- **Through a buying house / liaison office.** An intermediary represents the buyer locally: it places orders, follows production and controls quality for several factories, taking a commission for the service.
- **Through an agent.** An independent agent introduces buyer and factory and supports the relationship, usually on commission.
- **Through trade fairs, sourcing platforms and referrals.** New-buyer development routes: exhibitions, B2B platforms and recommendations from existing buyers or mills.
- **Repeat / running orders.** A satisfied buyer re-orders a proven style or programme — the cheapest order to collect and the easiest to execute, because sampling and costing are already established.

Types of order

TYPE	DISTINGUISHING FEATURE
Confirmed / bulk order	A signed PO with price, quantity and date; authorises booking and production.
Trial / test order	A small first order by which a buyer tests a new factory's quality and reliability.
Repeat order	The same style ordered again, often with quantity or colour changes only.
Development order	An order for samples / prototypes only, placed to develop a range before bulk decisions.
Programme order	A continuing series of orders for a core style across a season or year.

CMT / FOB / OEM-type arrangements	Classified by who supplies materials and design: in CMT the buyer supplies fabric and trims and pays conversion; in FOB the factory sources everything and quotes a full package price; in OEM / ODM-type work the factory also contributes design / development.

2. The time-and-action (T&A) calendar

A **T&A calendar** is the dated action plan of one order: every milestone that must happen between order confirmation and shipment, with a planned date and an owner. It is built **backwards from the shipment date**: vessel date fixes inspection, inspection fixes finishing, finishing fixes sewing, sewing fixes cutting, cutting fixes fabric in-house, and fabric in-house fixes booking and approval dates. The calendar converts a single deadline, which nobody can act on day by day, into dated duties that can be chased while delay is still recoverable. The merchandiser updates actual dates against planned dates; any milestone slipping is escalated immediately, because downstream activities cannot start early to compensate for materials that do not exist.

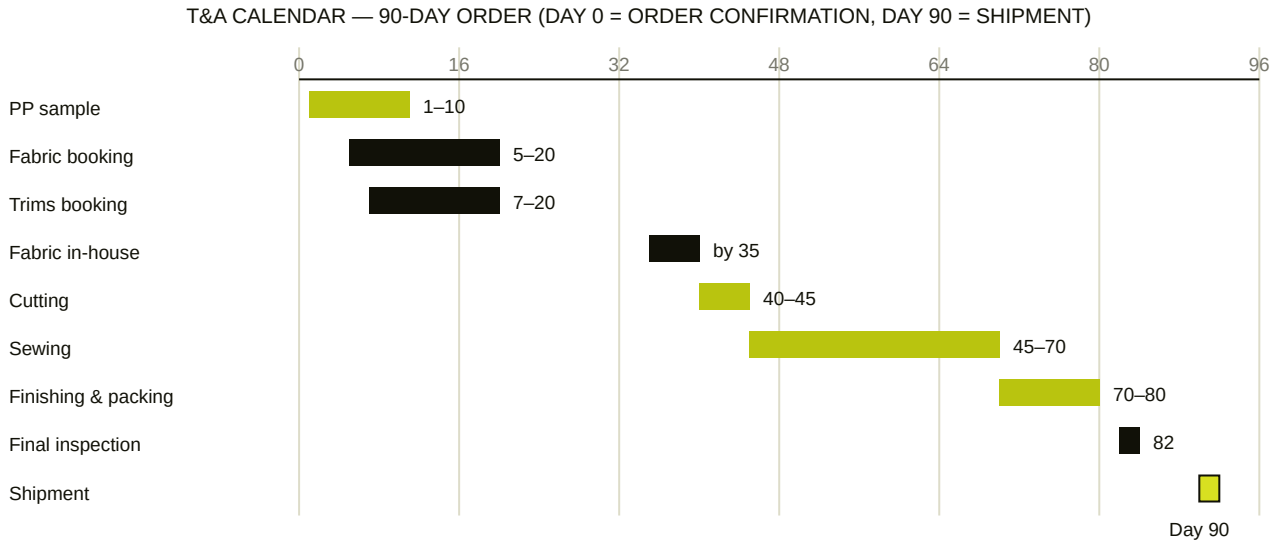


Figure 1 — Gantt-style T&A calendar for an illustrative 90-day order. Bars are drawn to the day ranges printed beside them; note how fabric booking overlaps sampling follow-up, while cutting cannot begin before fabric is in-house.

Reading the calendar. In the example, the PP sample occupies days 1–10; fabric and trims are booked while approval is being finalised (days 5–20 and 7–20) — a calculated overlap that protects the date but is only safe once the style is technically frozen. Fabric must be in-house by day 35, leaving a buffer before cutting on day 40. Sewing is the longest single block (days 45–70), finishing and packing follow (70–80), final inspection is booked at day 82, and day 90 is the shipment date. The gaps are not idleness: they are the buffer that absorbs a late vessel, a re-inspection or a finishing bottleneck.

3. The technical (tech) package

The **tech pack** (technical package / product package) is the complete written definition of the product, issued by the buyer and interpreted by the factory. Its **objective** is that any competent factory, reading only the pack, can make the same garment the buyer approved — it removes dependence on memory, verbal instruction and a single sample.

Elements of a tech pack

1. **Style summary / cover sheet** — style number, description, season, size range, colourways, order quantity.
2. **Technical sketches (flats)** — front, back and detail views with call-outs for every construction feature.
3. **Bill of materials (BOM)** — every fabric and trim with specification, supplier / quality reference, colour and placement.
4. **Measurement specification** — points of measurement, size chart for all sizes, grading between sizes, and tolerances (±) for each point.
5. **Construction specification** — seam types, stitch types, stitches per unit length, seam allowances, operation sequence notes.
6. **Artwork and placement** — print, embroidery and appliqué artwork with sizes, colours and exact positions.
7. **Wash / finish specification** — where applicable, the wash recipe target, hand-feel and appearance standard.
8. **Labels and packaging** — main label, care label, size label, hangtag, folding method, polybag and carton specifications and packing ratio.
9. **Quality and testing requirements** — performance standards the garment and fabric must meet, and the inspection basis.

> **OBJECTIVE IN ONE LINE**
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> The tech pack is the contract for the product itself: costing is priced from it, samples are judged against it, and bulk is inspected by it. An incomplete pack is not a small gap — every missing element becomes a factory assumption, and assumptions differ.

4. Analysis for various products

PRODUCT	WHAT ITS PACKAGE EMPHASISES	TYPICAL CRITICAL POINTS

Basic T-shirt (knit)	Fabric GSM and composition, chest / length / sleeve measurements, neck rib specification, print placement if any, packing ratio by size and colour.	GSM and shrinkage control, neck shape retention, print position and colour fastness.
Woven shirt	Detailed construction: collar, cuff, placket, yoke and pocket specifications; interlining quality; button specification and placement; stripe / check matching rules.	Collar construction and appearance, pattern matching at pocket and placket, buttonhole quality, pressing standard.
Pants (trouser)	Waist, hip, thigh, knee and leg-opening measurements; inseam lengths; fly construction; waistband and pocket specifications; wash specification for denim / washed styles.	Fit through waist and seat, leg twist control, wash consistency across the order, shrinkage after wash.

The pattern across products is constant — measurements, materials, construction, packaging — but the *risk points* move: for the T-shirt they sit in the fabric, for the shirt in construction detail, for pants in fit and wash. A merchandiser reads a new pack by hunting its product-specific risks first.

5. New order development

Developing a new order — converting an enquiry into a confirmed, executable order — proceeds in steps:

1. **Enquiry analysis.** Read the tech pack; identify product risks, required capacities and any specification the factory cannot meet.
2. **Consumption and costing.** Estimate fabric and trim consumption and build the cost sheet (Topic 4); confirm capacity and lead time with production.
3. **Quotation.** Quote price with validity, payment terms and shipment basis clearly stated.
4. **Development sampling.** Make the development / proto sample (Topic 3) so the buyer sees the product, not only a price.
5. **Negotiation and confirmation.** Settle price, quantity and date (Topic 1); receive the PO; check it line by line against the quotation — discrepancies are resolved before acceptance, never after production.
6. **Order set-up.** Issue the T&A calendar, open the order file, book capacity, and hand the confirmed specification to sampling, sourcing and production.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING

T&A calendar	Time-and-action calendar: the dated milestone plan of an order, built backwards from shipment.
Tech pack	The technical package defining a garment completely: sketches, BOM, measurements, construction, artwork and packing.
BOM	Bill of materials: the list of all fabrics and trims with specification and placement.
Buying house	An intermediary that represents a buyer locally and places and follows orders with factories.
Tolerance	The permitted deviation (±) from a specified measurement.

Key points and summary

- Orders arrive directly, through buying houses or agents, at fairs and by repeat business; they are classified as trial, repeat, development, programme or confirmed bulk, and by who supplies materials and design (CMT, FOB, OEM-type).
- The T&A calendar is built backwards from shipment and assigns a date and owner to every milestone; the merchandiser chases planned vs. actual daily.
- The tech pack's objective is reproducibility: sketches, BOM, measurements with tolerances, construction, artwork, labels and packing, and test requirements.
- Each product's package stresses different risks — fabric for a T-shirt, construction for a woven shirt, fit and wash for pants.
- New order development runs: analysis → costing → quotation → development sample → negotiation → PO check → T&A and order set-up.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. An order ships on day 90. Sewing needs 25 days and cannot start until fabric is in-house and cutting (5 days) is complete; finishing needs 10 days after sewing and final inspection needs 2 days after finishing. Work backwards: what is the latest day fabric can be in-house?
2. A tech pack gives a woven shirt's chest measurement but no tolerance and no stripe-matching rule. State two distinct production risks this creates.
3. Why is a repeat order normally cheaper to develop than a new-buyer trial order of the same quantity?

4. A buyer asks the factory to start fabric booking before PP approval. Using the T&A logic, state the benefit and the risk.

Answer key

1. Inspection ends by day 90, so finishing must end by day 88 and start by day 78; sewing must end by day 78 and start by day 53; cutting must end by day 53 and start by day 48. Fabric must therefore be in-house before cutting starts — by day 48 at the latest (in practice earlier, to hold a buffer).
2. (1) Without tolerance, inspection has no objective pass / fail boundary for chest, so acceptable garments can be disputed. (2) Without a matching rule, pocket and placket stripes may be cut unmatched — an appearance defect the buyer will reject even though measurements are correct.
3. Sampling, costing and specification are already established and approved, capacity behaviour is known, and no new-buyer testing of the factory is needed — development cost and risk are both lower.
4. Benefit: booking overlaps approval, protecting the shipment date. Risk: if the PP sample is rejected or changed, booked fabric may be wrong in quality, colour or quantity, and the cost of the change falls somewhere disputed.

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